REBEL LEADERS / FIELD TOOL 02



Deadline Reset

THE PRODUCT LEADER'S FIELD GUIDE

Leave with a delivery conversation you can defend, and an update stakeholders can act on.

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For you, the PM carrying this situation

OPEN YOUR LAB >

UNDERSTAND THE PRESSURE. WORK THE SITUATION. LEAVE WITH A MOVE.

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The date matters. So does the work.

Someone has already promised a date. You're the PM who now has to connect that promise to what the team can responsibly deliver.

Respect the reason for the date

A launch event, contract, customer commitment, or funding window may be real. Start by understanding the consequence of missing it. That helps you shape an alternative that serves the actual need.

Separate three different things

A forecast describes what the evidence currently suggests. A commitment names what somebody has agreed to do under conditions. A target names what people want. Ask which one this date is, who owns it, and which scope it covers.

Your win as the PM

Help the room choose between viable options, protect the conditions required to ship, and give stakeholders an update they can use. You don't need to make uncertainty disappear to lead the next decision.

How this kit helps

Read the Guide for judgment and language. Use the Lab for one live commitment. Leave with a Reality Map, an Options Brief, and a Stakeholder Update you can review before sharing.

> Start with one date and one promised outcome. You can use the Lab before the meeting, then finish the decision record afterward.

Get clear before you go back into the room.

A deadline can feel like a judgment on your competence. Take a few minutes to separate that pressure from the decision the organization needs.

Separate the event from your interpretation

Write the actual request, words, or decision. Then name the story you're adding about the person. You can feel frustrated and still ask a useful question about their constraints.

Name your Why

Who is depending on this delivery? What would a useful, trustworthy release change for them? Make that outcome the reason for the reset; the point is to serve it responsibly.

Paint a future they can help shape

Describe what better would look like in daily work: customers can plan, the team can focus, or decisions happen before commitments change. Invite the other person to improve the picture. A shared ambition needs their authorship too.

Keep private preparation private

The Lab saves these notes in your browser and excludes them from shared outputs. Export the working brief you want others to see; don't send your untested motive story.

> Try: I want us to make this work. Can we look together at the outcome, the constraints, and the decision we need?

What is fixed, and who says so?

The first job is to stop treating every part of the promise as equally immovable.

Capture the actual promise

Write the communicated date, scope, recipient, and person who made the commitment. An internal target and an external contractual promise may need different owners and different communication.

Check the constraint

Record the source: event booking, contract, regulatory requirement, or accountable stakeholder. If a constraint needs interpretation, ask the relevant owner. Don't turn your own assumption into a rule.

Name the unknowns

List uncertain scope, integration dependencies, approvals, and capacity. For each important unknown, identify who can check it and what evidence would change the plan.

Use delivery evidence

Work with your lead on completed work, remaining work, team capacity, and dependencies. A desired date is not evidence of feasibility. The Lab records your assessment; it does not generate a schedule.

> Reality Map: what was promised, what is genuinely constrained, and what still needs evidence.

Give them a choice they can actually make.

A vague warning that the date is risky leaves leadership with the same problem. Put credible alternatives beside the current promise.

Keep the date; change the scope

Define the smallest useful customer outcome for that window. Say what it includes, what moves later, and what it would let people do. Ask Engineering to assess it before calling it feasible.

Keep the scope; revisit the date

Use a team-supported forecast or describe the assessment needed. Keep dependencies and confidence visible. Don't invent a precise new date merely to replace an uncomfortable old one.

Change capacity only when it helps

A specialist, a resolved dependency, or removing other work may help. More people can also add onboarding and review. Name the actual change and get the delivery team's judgment.

Protect the release conditions

Quality, security, safety, and required approvals are part of usable delivery. Reducing scope can be a responsible trade; silently removing those checks changes the risk people are agreeing to.

> Recommend one option, explain its consequence, and show the credible alternative.

Make your confidence explainable.

A confidence label is only useful when the reader knows which plan it describes and why you hold it.

Attach confidence to a specific plan

Medium confidence in the core workflow by November 1 says more than medium confidence in the project. Name the scope, date, team, and important conditions.

State the basis

Name the completed work, delivery assessment, confirmed dependency, or unresolved risk. Low, medium, and high in this Lab are qualitative judgments. They are not calculated percentages.

Choose an evidence checkpoint

What will materially change the assessment? A tested integration, an approval, or acceptance of the smaller workflow? Name the owner and date, not only another status meeting.

Say what changes if the evidence fails

Agree when a failed dependency check should trigger a scope or date decision. That gives stakeholders a response plan while there is still time to act.

> Try: For this scope, our confidence is medium because the integration is unverified. Thursday's check will tell us whether we can keep this plan.

Reset the plan while protecting trust.

You are helping the organization keep a worthwhile promise in a form the work can support.

Open with the shared outcome

I know the event matters. I want customers to have a reliable workflow they can actually use there. Here's what the team currently knows, and the choice that would help us protect that outcome.

But we've already promised it

Ask who owns changing the external commitment. Offer the smaller outcome and the communication needed. Don't assume you can revise a customer promise on someone else's behalf.

Can't the team just push harder?

Show the constraint that effort alone will not remove: access approval, integration evidence, specialist review, or missing capacity. Offer a real tradeoff with its owner.

I need a yes or no

State what you can support now, which part is still unverified, and when the evidence arrives. If a commitment is required sooner, name the risk and route that decision to the accountable owner.

> Useful language: I recommend this option to protect the customer outcome. Here is its cost, and here is the decision I need from you.

Keep the event. Reset the assumed launch.

Fictional case: a sponsor has promised a full launch for a November 1 customer event before an integration has been verified.

The Reality Map

The event date is confirmed. Full reporting at launch is an assumption. The team has evidence on the core workflow, but the integration remains a delivery condition.

The Options Brief

Option A: core workflow for the event, reporting later, subject to Thursday's integration check. Option B: retain full scope and reassess the delivery range. Security and acceptance checks stay required.

The recommendation

PM recommends A. Medium confidence applies only to the smaller scope under the integration condition. The sponsor must approve the scope reset and own the external update by Wednesday.

The decision and follow-through

In this fictional case, the sponsor accepts the smaller scope and owns the customer update. PM records agreement after the meeting. Thursday's integration check remains a condition; a failed check returns the plan to the sponsor. The Lab example begins with the proposal so you can rehearse this conversation.

> They leave with one shared plan, a clear customer message, and a checkpoint that can change the commitment.

One situation. Three useful records.

Open your Deadline Reset Lab on your phone or computer. Nic's walkthrough follows this same process on a realistic example.

Reality

Enter the outcome, promise, source of the constraint, assumptions, and unknowns. Use the private questions to prepare yourself. Build the Reality Map when you need to check the facts with someone.

Options

Describe scope, date, and capacity alternatives. Select your recommendation and explain it. Export the Options Brief for the conversation; selecting an option does not approve it.

Confidence

Name the scope your confidence applies to, evidence behind it, and the next checkpoint. Avoid treating the label as a probability.

Update

Name the decision, owner, needed-by date, and communication plan. Record the actual response when it happens. Copy, download, or print the Stakeholder Update for your existing work tools.

> To rehearse, choose Load fictional example. Export your current draft first if you need to keep it.

Use the next conversation to learn.

A useful brief changes what happens next. Give it an owner, take it into your existing work tools, and return to the evidence.

Follow through on one move

After the decision, make sure the sponsor updates the people who relied on the original promise. Revisit confidence when the agreed evidence arrives. A revised plan without revised communication leaves the old commitment alive.

Rehearse with a trusted peer

Read your opening aloud. Ask: Is the observation fair? Is the recommendation specific? Could the other person disagree without being cast as the villain? Revise the wording before the real conversation.

Keep a record you can return to

Lab drafts stay in this browser on this device. Copy, download, or print your outputs. Export before clearing browser data or moving devices. The tool does not send messages, update your roadmap, or create authority.

Judge the change by what happens

What did the other person hear? Was a decision made? Did anyone act? Review the next real result rather than treating completion of the Lab as proof that the organizational problem is solved.

> You arrive with a situation. You leave with a proposal, a decision record, or a specific question that somebody can act on.